Lebanon or risk losing the advantage it had gained over the PLO and Syria in a war that had cost hundreds of Israeli casualties. The Soviets, meanwhile, had responded to Israel's crushing defeat of Syrian military forces and their Soviet-built weapons by sending the Syrians an array of their most modern arms.

We agreed that Israel had reason to be concerned about the safety of Israelis living in towns and villages near its northern border, but Habib, George Shultz, and I constantly reassured Begin that if Israel lived up to its agreement to pull its forces out of Lebanon, the United States would not allow it to be disadvantaged. Begin, however, wouldn't move. This left my Middle East peace initiative in limbo. Meanwhile, Israel added new settlements on the West Bank, which was in continued violation of UN Security Council Resolution 242 and ignored a cornerstone of my peace initiative. Long-term resolution of the Middle East's problems seemed further than ever from our grasp.

There were millions of Palestinians scattered throughout the Middle East, and all of them looked upon Israel and the West Bank (where 1.7 million Palestinians already lived) as their natural homeland. It seemed obvious that we weren't going to find an enduring Middle East peace until the world found a place for these Palestinians. Even though Israel claimed its ancestors' occupancy of the land gave it a right to the land in modern times, the Palestinians exerted an ancestral claim of their own on the West Bank: Their ancestors, too, had lived there for centuries.

During a visit to Washington early in 1983 in which he reiterated his desire to be a strong friend to the United States, President Mubarak of Egypt told me Israel's continuing refusal to leave Lebanon and its establishment of more settlements on the West Bank were inflaming the Arab world and reducing the momentum that had started to build up in favor of the September initiative. If progress wasn't